THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

Goodhart's law

When a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

Apple asked engineers to count their code

LISA PROJECT · WEEKLY REPORT

Name: Bill Atkinson

Week of: February 1982

Lines of code written this week:

−2000

He'd rewritten QuickDraw's regions

Speed 6.0×

Code −2,000

line count, illustrative

They stopped asking him

Andy Hertzfeld, folklore.org

When a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure



Goodhart's law

Charles Goodhart, 1975 · this wording: Marilyn Strathern, 1997

Hanoi, 1902. To fight plague:

1 cent per rat tail



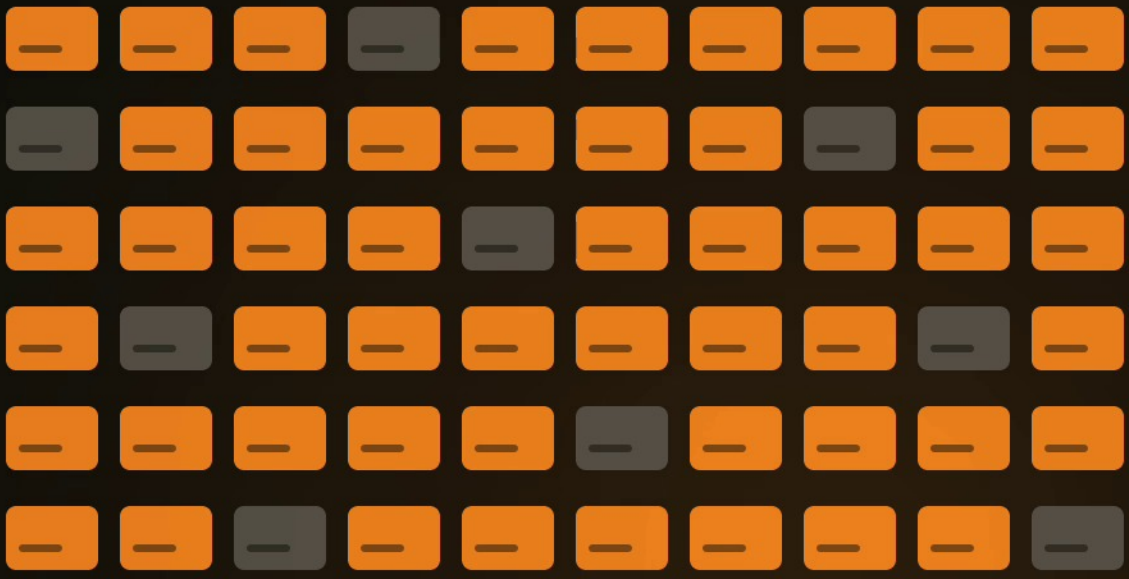
`tails paid for: 42  rats: still here`

Cut the tail. Release the rat. Breed more

The bounty was cancelled · historian Michael G. Vann

Wells Fargo's goal:

8 products per customer



up to **3.5M**

accounts possibly opened without consent

$3 billion settlement, 2020

Ivan Rykov

Your team does this too

Lines of code
→ code bloats

Story points
→ estimates inflate

Tickets closed
→ closed, not fixed

Test coverage
→ tests that check nothing

Never chase one number

Pair metrics that pull against each other



Even DORA warns: don't make its metrics a target

Ivan Rykov ftware delivery metrics

So, stop measuring?

No



Measure to learn, not to judge

TAKEAWAY

Measure to learn, not to judge

Sources: Charles Goodhart, 1975 · Marilyn Strathern, 1997 · Andy Hertzfeld, folklore.org · DORA

next: Sturgeon's law